

priests. Since that is the only reference on retirement in the entire Bible, I believe the concept we have about retirement today is somewhat out of balance.

As we get older we will normally change our work patterns. A 50-year-old man rarely does the same things at 50 he did at 25. Most who live to be 75 won't do the same things they're doing at 50. But most can be doing something productive for the Lord if they plan properly.

I recall a study done by a major university. They surveyed 200 65-year-old men who were graduates of their school, eliminating those with bad health, heart trouble, et cetera. They maintained contact with these men from ages 65 to 75. One half of the study group retired at 65 and the other had continued their careers. At age 75, of the group that had retired, 6 out of 7 had died. Of the group that did not retire, 6 out of 7 were still alive.

The conclusion of this study was: a man's probability of dying if he stops work at 65 goes up approximately 500 to 600 percent. So if you want to live longer, stay active.

Let's look at retirement from a practical perspective. If you're not going to be able to do the same things at 65 that you were able to do at 25, then you need to be preparing for that contingency. If these are the harvest years of your life, then you should put something aside for the winter years. Or if you desire to do volunteer work with a ministry after retirement, then you'll need to have some surplus funds set aside, and there's nothing wrong with that.

But the point at which a Christian orients his or her life toward retirement, something is out of balance. I think of what David wrote: "I have been young, and now I am old; yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken, or his descendants begging bread" (Psalm 37:25). We need to remember that.

GUIDELINES FOR RETIREMENT

(1) *God intends that we be productive.* So plan something later in life that you can do to earn a living. If you're a school teacher and you don't think you can continue teaching school